Opposition Discourse under a Competitive Authoritarian Regime

Computational Discourse Analysis
of the Republican People's Party
Türkiye (2015–2026)

Candidate number: 63884

Supervised by Dr. Bohdana Kurylo

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Department of Methodology
London School of Economics and Political Science

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To my mother and grandmother

Abstract

Although authoritarian discourse is well documented and scholarship on opposition politics has recently flourished, discourse is systematically treated as derivative of strategy rather than as an object of analysis in its own right. To address this gap, the study asks: *How does the discourse of the Republican People's Party shift around the critical events of Türkiye's autocratisation between 2015 and 2026, and how long do those shifts last?* Drawing on a corpus of roughly 2,700 speeches by the party's two leaders, it represents four signifiers through target-masked contextual embeddings, clusters these into articulations, reads them with class-based TF-IDF and traces their shift across three leadership phases. The four signifiers move in four distinct patterns rather than one: *the nation* expands into an empty signifier while the chain does not close around it, *the people* contracts into sedimentation, *democracy* is rebuilt around a collective subject, and *right* disperses. Taken together they describe a *distributed articulation* rather than consolidation on a single empty signifier. Dislocatory events reactivate distinct registers rather than following a single law, and discursive change is processual rather than event-driven. Finally, the study extends the Essex School's discourse-theoretical tradition by bridging the distributional hypothesis with Laclauian articulation, and it deposits the assembled corpus for further research.

Data and Code Availability

The code required to reproduce every step of the analysis, from preprocessing to the figures and tables reported here, is available at https://github.com/LSE-63884-2526/capstone.git.

The speech corpus and the contextual embedding vectors on which the analysis is based are deposited at huggingface.co/datasets/athena753/CHP2015_2026.

Full contextual meta-cluster tables for all four signifiers are provided in the accompanying Supplementary Information.

Contents

Abstract **i**

Data and Code Availability ii

1 Introduction **1**

2 Political Opposition Literature **4**

2.1 Agency or Structure? 4

2.2 Strategies 6

2.3 Problematisation 7

3 Theoretical Framework **10**

3.1 The Articulated Universe of Ernesto Laclau 12

3.2 Operationalising the Post-Structuralist Discourse Theory 14

4 Casing the Republican People's Party **16**

5 Methodology **20**

5.1 Data and Preprocessing 20

5.2 Methods 21

5.3 Reflexivity 26

6 Findings **27**

6.1 Lexical Analysis 27

6.2 Semantic Analysis 30

6.2.1 *hak*: Dispersal 30

6.2.2 *demokrasi*: Replacement 34

6.2.3 *millet*: The Widening Chain 37

6.2.4 *halk*: Sedimentation 40

6.3 Four Patterns 42

7 Discussion **44**

7.1 Contribution and Future Work 46

7.2 Limitations 46

A Robustness and Sensitivity Analyses **49**

1 Introduction

The last quarter of the twentieth century reshaped the world's political landscape. In 1974, the Estado Novo in Portugal and the military junta in Greece were overthrown. A year later, Franco's death set in motion the dissolution of the dictatorship in Spain. In Latin America, the 1980s witnessed the replacement of military dictatorships with civilian governments (e.g. Argentina, Brazil). In South Korea, the student-led June Democratic Uprising of 1987 drew in the urban middle class and led to the first democratic elections in the country. The Solidarity movement and 1989 elections in Poland triggered the domino effect for the Soviet Bloc's satellite states and they broke from communism one by one, culminating in the dissolution of the USSR in 1991. All of these disparate events were famously described as the *third wave of democratisation*[1] (Huntington, 1991).

This process was not merely about a series of regime changes. The wave sparked a strong belief in global democratisation and the assumption that this change had a direction became entrenched. Such optimism was widely institutionalised by the "new democracy-promotion community" in the U.S., with officials referring to the developments as the "worldwide democratic revolution" (Carothers, 2002, pp. 5–6). Later on, Carothers labelled this frame the *transition paradigm* and summarised the core assumption as "any country moving away from dictatorial rule can be considered a country in transition toward democracy" (Carothers, 2002, p. 6).

Yet the trajectories on the ground rarely matched the paradigm. The notion of a transition to democracy operated as an all-encompassing ideal type: roughly 100

[1] Huntington identified the preceding waves as 1828–1926 and 1943–1962, with reverse waves as 1922–1942 and 1958–1975, respectively.

countries were labelled "transitional". In practice, only a small fraction, such as Poland, Hungary, Chile, and Taiwan, showed genuine movement toward democracy and others fell into a "gray zone" (Carothers, 2002, p. 9).

Levitsky and Way (2002) echo this diagnosis in the academic literature. Scholarly work on emerging hybrid regimes often treats empirical cases as attenuated versions of democracy, a tendency they call "democratising bias". Concepts such as "semidemocracy", "virtual democracy", and "illiberal democracy" obscure the differences between heterogeneous cases and the underlying causal mechanisms that produce them. Drawing on Linz (2000), these regimes are better understood not as partial democracies but as "diminished forms of authoritarianism" (Levitsky & Way, 2002, pp. 51–52). Accordingly, the question is no longer how far a case has advanced toward democracy but what kind of regime it is and how it is sustained.

In the wake of these critiques, the literature redirected attention to *hybrid regimes* that combine democratic and authoritarian elements (Diamond, 2002), among which *competitive authoritarianism* stood out as a prominent category (Levitsky & Way, 2002). In such regimes, the formal apparatus of democracy remains the main route to gaining and wielding power. However, the incumbent tilts the competitive field in its favour through tactics such as strategic election manipulation, media capture, and selective prosecution of opposition figures, producing an "uneven playing field" (Levitsky & Way, 2002, p. 53). The framework was applied to a wide range of cases, including Russia, Venezuela, and Hungary. Türkiye is also considered a paradigmatic case of competitive authoritarianism (Özbudun, 2015; Esen & Gumuscu, 2016; Levitsky & Way, 2020).

Two decades later, Levitsky and Way (2020) revisited the concept and observed that the cases which emerged more recently differ from those on which it was originally built. In Hungary, the Philippines, Türkiye, and Venezuela, democratic institutions were stronger, civil society more vibrant, and opposition parties better organised than in the countries where competitive authoritarianism was first identified. Incumbents there "confronted oppositions with the resources to effectively mobilize supporters both

on the streets and at the ballot box", which made tilting the playing field a considerably harder task (Levitsky & Way, 2020, p. 59).

Although the asymmetry gives the incumbent a significant advantage, it does not guarantee victory. Opposition forces have defeated autocratic incumbents or their chosen successors in Nicaragua (1990), Zambia (1991), Malawi and Ukraine (1994), Albania (1997) and Ghana (2000), and Milošević's attempt to falsify the 2000 Serbian results triggered a regime crisis that ended in his removal (Levitsky & Way, 2002). Recently, opposition victories halted or reversed autocratisation in North Macedonia (2016), Ecuador (2018), Poland (2023) (Muliavka et al., 2025; Tomini et al., 2023), and most recently in Hungary (2026), with Tisza bringing Orbán's 16-year "illiberal state" to an end ("After the Election," 2026). In Türkiye, the opposition has not displaced the incumbent nationally, but its victories in the 2019 and 2024 local elections broke the ruling party's monopoly over municipal resources in metropolitan cities (Yavuzyılmaz & Esen, 2025). Taken together, these outcomes make the opposition a consequential actor rather than a residual category. As oppositions pose genuine challenges to authoritarian incumbents, the strategies and tactics they pursue become an increasingly important object of social scientific inquiry. This thesis takes that actor as its object and analyses the discourse of Türkiye's main opposition party between 2015 and 2026.

The thesis proceeds as follows. Chapter 2 reviews the literature on opposition under autocratisation and identifies the gap it addresses, which is that discourse is relied upon to explain outcomes while being treated as derivative of strategy. Chapter 3 sets out the concepts taken from post-structuralist discourse theory and states the theoretical question. Chapter 4 builds the case and dates the events around which the analysis is organised, and Chapter 5 reports the corpus and the two analytical layers. Chapter 6 presents the results for the four signifiers, and Chapter 7 reads them together and states the limits of what they support.

2 Political Opposition Literature

Tilting the playing field is not a single act but a sequence. The literature captures that sequence through the concept of *autocratisation*. Autocratisation emphasizes detectable periods in which individual or collective actors "make the exercise of political power more arbitrary and repressive, restricting the space for public contestation and political participation" (Tomini et al., 2023, p. 121). It is an "umbrella concept" that covers democratic backsliding, democratic breakdown, and authoritarian deepening (Tomini et al., 2023). Today, democratic backsliding occurs gradually, rather than through the sudden events of the past such as executive coups and election-day fraud (Bermeo, 2016). On the same wave logic that framed democratisation, this period has been identified as a *third wave of autocratisation*, one that began in 1994 (Lührmann & Lindberg, 2019). Elected leaders dismantle checks on their power and introduce institutional changes that weaken their rivals, in a process Bermeo terms *executive aggrandizement* (Bermeo, 2016, p. 10). The opposition's position is therefore ambivalent. It must operate within institutions it cannot reject, even as those same institutions are turned against it by the incumbent.

2.1 Agency or Structure?

This ambivalent actor has nonetheless remained one of the most neglected topics in political science (Helms, 2023; Tomini et al., 2023), even though the first study on democratic opposition appeared sixty years ago (Dahl, 1966). Helms (2023) strikingly illustrates this gap by pointing to the *Oxford Handbook of Legislative Politics*, devoting no chapter to opposition parties and omitting the term entirely from its index. To con-

ceptualise the opposition, he suggests an "inclusive understanding" in which varying adjectives such as "anti-system parties", "anti-elitist parties", "new challenger parties", and "pariah parties" are subsumed under the umbrella of non-governing parties. Yabancı et al. (2025) broaden this further, treating the opposition as a "dynamic virtual space" where "different actors may enter or exit this space at any given time, depending on shifting political contexts and strategies" (Yabanci et al., 2025, p. 98). Alongside political resisters, which in most cases are opposition parties, Tomini et al. (2023) identify institutional resisters inside state bodies and social resisters organised at the grassroots.

This widening has a limit. Helms cautions that resistance and opposition do not share the same theoretical ground, and that treating such phenomena as synonyms risks "conceptual stretching" (Helms, 2023).

Leaving aside conceptual tensions, this "widely scattered" (Helms, 2023, p. 392) literature builds a consensus that the study of opposition under backsliding should adopt an agency-based approach (Cleary & Öztürk, 2022; Tomini et al., 2023; Balta & Demiralp, 2024). This marks a departure from earlier studies of authoritarian resilience and the menu of manipulation (Schedler, 2002), altering the focus toward opposition coordination and agency (Balta & Demiralp, 2024). In empirical terms, Gamboa (2017) argues that structural differences, such as economic development and state power, do not necessarily account for diverging outcomes in Venezuela and Colombia.

Scholarly work on political opposition has recently been criticised by Weyland (2025) on two fronts. The first is that agency-focused accounts are dis-embedded, since opposition choices are made under institutional and structural conditions largely beyond the opposition's control. The second proactively delves deep into how the actor is studied. Attributing outcomes to opposition agency obscures that the opposition is primarily reactive. This is mainly because the initiative lies with the incumbent, who moves first against institutional checks, concentrates power, and applies pressure to rivals, civil society, and the press, leaving the opposition to respond from a position it did not choose and at times with no viable option at all. Reading outcomes off opposition strategy

therefore risks “blaming the victim” (Weyland, 2025, p. 2).

2.2 Strategies

Gamboa (2017) separates two elements that most accounts treat together, which are the arena in which the opposition acts and the goals that it pursues. Moderate goals protect the opposition’s legitimacy at home and abroad and raise the cost of repression, so the opposition keeps the institutional resources it still holds. This is true whether it works inside institutions or outside them, because the protection is lost through the radical goal rather than through the extra-institutional means. In Colombia the opposition used its institutional leverage and eventually blocked Uribe’s second re-election reform, whereas in Venezuela it gave up that leverage in order to remove Chávez from office, lost the resources it held, and helped him pass more far-reaching reforms.

Whether opposition parties can act together at all depends less on their willingness than on the structure of the divisions between them. Laštro and Bieber (2021) find that cross-cutting cleavages keep contestation fragmented, as in Montenegro and Serbia, while reinforcing cleavages allow different types of opposition actor to converge, as in North Macedonia. They also find that large protests before an election are more effective than boycotts, since a protest signals the breadth of support and holds the opposition together, which a boycott does not.

The Turkish literature reaches a similar conclusion from the other side, since it shows how a leading party can work on the cleavages that divide the opposition. Esen et al. (2026) describe a two-level strategy in which the CHP moderated its positions on the Turkish–Kurdish and the secular–Islamist cleavages while it deepened the democracy–autocracy cleavage, and they treat helalleşme as “the main discursive framework of CHP’s strategy of Downsian defence” (Esen et al., 2026, p. 18). The repertoire this

produced includes joint candidates, unified campaigns, transferred deputies and help in collecting presidential nomination signatures (Selçuk & Hekimci, 2020). Somer et al. (2021) place these moves within a broader account of counter-polarisation and single out the CHP's campaign manual, the Book of Radical Love (Wuthrich & Ingleby, 2020), as "perhaps the most notable innovation" (Somer et al., 2021, p. 13) of the period. Coordination of this kind is not self-executing, however. Yavuzyılmaz and Esen (2025) show that an alliance can be formally complete and still fail, because bargaining among unequal partners becomes opaque and candidate selection remains in the hands of the leadership.

Contestation also runs outside the national arena. Where opposition parties hold municipal office, a further strategy becomes available to them. Ayan Musil and Yardımcı-Geyikçi (2024) show that the mayors of Istanbul and Budapest built direct links with the liberal-democratic world through material, symbolic and political means, and that they did so in order to widen a room for manoeuvre that national institutions denied them. Taken together, these studies answer the question that the agency-based turn raised, because they show that opposition parties select arenas, set goals, build coalitions and reach beyond the national arena.

2.3 Problematisation

The literature theorises autocratisation as a *process*, such as "episodes" (Lührmann & Lindberg, 2019) and "incremental changes" (Bermeo, 2016). Opposition, by contrast, is observed around discrete events, chiefly elections, with some notable exceptions (Gessler, 2024; Muliavka et al., 2025; Selçuk et al., 2019). This largely stems from the dependent variables the literature operationalises (e.g. electoral victories, the passage or failure of reforms, the survival or fall of the incumbent). Coordination is assessed on the same terms. Its components are specified as routinised candidate nomination, transparent bargaining, coordinated campaign design, and post-election power-sharing

(Yavuzyılmaz & Esen, 2025), each defined around a single electoral cycle. Even the coordination repertoire is specified electorally, as joint candidates, unified campaigns, transferred deputies, and help in collecting presidential nomination signatures (Selçuk & Hekimci, 2020). The process is theorised continuously whereas the actor is sampled at intervals.

Discourse runs through each move of the opposition. Moderation is carried out in what a party says about religion and ethnicity, a coalition of ideologically distant partners needs a language in which its members can recognise one another (Esen et al., 2026), and transnational appeals are made in the vocabulary of democracy and rights (Ayan Musil & Yardımcı-Geyikçi, 2024).

In terms of the scope, Somer et al. (2021) frame this literature around objectives, strategies, and the tools that implement them, among which discourse figures as one such tool, entering the analysis through recruitment methods, emotional and symbolic appeals, and narratives (e.g. helalleşme[1] normalisation[2]). A similar perspective adapted across the literature. Discourse is consistently treated as attached to something else, a tool of strategy rather than an object of analysis in its own right. Yet the same literature leans on discourse whenever it explains outcomes. The framework thus renders discourse derivative while the explanations rest on it, leaving it an *epiphenomenon*, something "secondary or derivative of a more profound reality" (Thomassen, 2024, p. 143). Discursive constitution, however, is itself a process, and it cannot be recovered from observations taken at electoral intervals.

Echoing Weyland's (2025) critique, whether the opposition is only reactive is an empirical question, and answering it requires observing what it says between the incumbent's moves, not only in response to them. By doing so, the research operationalises Post-Structuralist Discourse theory (Laclau, 2005; Laclau & Mouffe, 1985)

[1]A reconciliation discourse introduced by Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu, then CHP leader, from February 2021 onwards (first appearance in the corpus),

[2]A process initiated after the March 2024 local elections, aiming to reduce polarisation, radical love (Wuthrich & Ingleby, 2020)

to trace crystallised patterns in the Republican People's Party discourse between 2015 and 2026. The study therefore asks: *How does that discourse shift around the critical events of the period, and how long do those shifts last?*

3 Theoretical Framework

In this chapter I first outline the *discursive logic* as one of the most debated explanations of the long contested concept of *populism*, drawing on the work of Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe (Laclau & Mouffe, 1985; Laclau, 2005). I then set out the concepts this thesis takes from that tradition, and I close by stating the theoretical question the analysis answers and the point at which the design meets Laclau's own unit of analysis.

Populism in this tradition names a *logic of articulation* rather than an ideology or a strategy (Laclau, 2005). The analysis that follows draws on that logic as an analytical apparatus and does not advance a diagnosis of populism, since the question here is not whether the Republican People's Party belongs to a category but how it builds and rebuilds the relations between the terms it uses. Whether the party is populist under the ideational or the strategic definitions is a separate question, and it is one this thesis leaves open.

Taking the apparatus without the label still carries an obligation, because a theory of this kind is not a set of concepts that can be lifted away from the account of reality that produced them. If meaning is never fully fixed and the social has no ground outside discourse, then a method that assumes stable meaning, or that treats a text as a window onto something behind it, would contradict the theory at the level where the theory makes its strongest claim (Thomassen, 2024; Marttila, 2015). What is required is therefore not only that the method produce reliable results but that its assumptions and the ontology remain in harmony. This requirement runs through every decision reported in the following chapter, and it is the reason those decisions are justified there in terms of what they do to the reading of articulation rather than in terms of accuracy

alone (Glynos & Howarth, 2019).

Two limits of scope follow from the same commitment. Laclau warns that discourse is not restricted to speech and writing but covers "any complex of elements in which relations play the constitutive role" (Laclau, 2005, p. 68). This thesis observes one modality of that complex, the spoken record, and it does not reach the practices, institutions and actions that the same ontology counts as discursive. Nor does it trace the Lacanian, Gramscian and Althusserian lineages of these categories, or the affective dimension Laclau develops alongside them, since the reading offered here runs through Saussure.

3.1 The Articulated Universe of Ernesto Laclau

Table 3.1: The signifier from Saussure to Laclau. The right-hand column gives the formulation this thesis works from.

Term	Formulation
sign	A signifier bound to a signified, whose value is not positive but differential, since in language there are "no positive terms…only differences"[a]
discourse	"any complex of elements in which relations play the constitutive role", so that elements "do not pre-exist the relational complex but are constituted through it". On this account " 'relation' and 'objectivity' are synonymous"[b]
empty signifier	"strictly speaking, a signifier without a signified", a formulation Laclau offers as "the enunciation of a problem" rather than as a definition, since a signifier detached from every signified would cease to signify at all[c]
	The operation that resolves the problem is hegemonic: "the hegemonic identity becomes something of the order of an empty signifier", a particular name coming to stand for the chain as a whole[d]
floating signifier	A signifier under "the structural pressure of rival hegemonic projects", whose meaning is "indeterminate between alternative equivalential frontiers" and in that sense "suspended"[e]

[a] Saussure (1993), in the reading Laclau gives at (Laclau, 2005, p. 68).
[b] (Laclau, 2005, p. 68).
[c] (Laclau, 1996, p. 36).
[d] (Laclau, 2005, p. 71).
[e] (Laclau, 2005, p. 131). Empty and floating are not two kinds of signifier but "partial dimensions…in any process of hegemonic construction" (Laclau, 2005, p. 133).

Table 3.1 sets out the terms this thesis takes from that tradition.

Laclau names two modes in which the social is constructed. The first links particularities differentially, which is the Saussurean case of no positive terms and only differences. The second surrenders part of that particularity in favour of what the particularities have in common. Only the second divides the social by an antagonistic frontier, and this is where the account leaves Saussure behind, since a closed system of differences has no outside against which an equivalence could form (Laclau, 2005, p. 78). Laclau cautions that the two are not in a zero-sum relation, and the same cau-

tion governs the empty and the floating signifier, which are dimensions of one process rather than two kinds of term (Laclau, 2005, p. 133).

Laclau's own example is the Russian Revolution, where "all the antagonisms within Russian society were condensed in a ruptural unity around demands for 'bread, peace and land'". What made those three demands carry more than their own content was the investment in them of empty terms such as justice and freedom, so that they "became the names of a universality that transcended their actual particular contents" (Laclau, 2005, p. 97).

The hegemonic identity, in Laclau's formulation, "becomes something of the order of an empty signifier" (Laclau, 2005, p. 71), a name that comes to stand for the whole chain, through which the people is constituted relationally. The smallest unit here is the demand, something in transition from request to claim, which can include struggles, grievances and local requests. This practice is articulatory, which is constitutive of the social. The heterogeneous web of articulations rendered equivalent is what constitutes a hegemonic project, and one demand can be elevated to represent the whole chain, functioning as an *empty signifier* (e.g. justice, democracy, the people).

Articulation fixes meaning only partially, since the nodal points around which a discourse gathers never exhaust the field of differences they draw on (Laclau & Mouffe, 1985, p. 105). What a corpus yields is therefore a series of provisional snapshots rather than a settled meaning. Two further terms enter from Husserl, whose account of sedimentation Laclau adapts to a political ontology (Laclau, 1990, pp. 33–34). A sedimented articulation is one whose contingency has been forgotten, and dislocation is the moment at which an event cannot be symbolised in the terms the discourse has available.

The relation between the nodal point and the empty signifier is unsettled in the literature, and it is not clear "whether the empty signifier is simply synonymous with the nodal point, a refinement of the original concept, or picks out and captures different

aspects of social reality" (Zicman de Barros, 2025). This thesis therefore uses *node* descriptively for the interpretive groupings reported in Chapter 6 and reserves *empty signifier* for the operation described above.

3.2 Operationalising the Post-Structuralist Discourse Theory

The tradition that supplies this vocabulary has been criticised for the distance between the reach of its ontology and the thinness of its procedures. Because articulation operates at the ontological level, it does not by itself tell the researcher which stretches of text to read, how many, or on what grounds one reading should be preferred over another. The result is that textual evidence is often selected after the interpretation has been formed, which leaves the approach open to the charge that its findings illustrate rather than test (Jacobs & Tschötschel, 2019; Nikisianis et al., 2019). This thesis treats that gap as a methodological problem with a methodological answer, and the answer is set out in the next chapter rather than here, since the decisions involved are decisions about procedure.

One point has to be recorded at the level of theory. Laclau makes the choice of the minimal unit the decisive one and takes as his smallest unit the category of "social demand" (Laclau, 2005, p. 73). This thesis works from the occurrence of a signifier in its immediate discursive company, and it does so in order to reach that unit rather than to replace it. What separates a democratic demand from a popular one is not a property of the demand in isolation. It is whether the demand persists without being met, whether it is voiced widely enough to be recognised as shared, and whether it can gather heterogeneous claims around itself. All three are properties of how a demand is articulated over time, and all three leave traces that a corpus can be made to show. A demand that is absorbed institutionally recedes and does not return. A demand

that becomes popular accumulates company, and the signifier that carries it grows extensionally while it loses particular content. Reading articulation at the semantic and the lexical level at once is therefore not a step below Laclau's unit but the route by which that unit becomes observable across eleven years rather than at the moments an interpreter selects.

Put in theoretical terms, the question this thesis answers is the following. *What holds an opposition discourse together when the structure it works in is being dislocated, and does such a discourse settle on one central signifier or spread across several?*

In the terms the design can observe, that becomes a question about four of them. *How does the Republican People's Party rearticulate* hak, demokrasi, millet *and* halk *between 2015 and 2026?*

4 Casing the Republican People's Party

The empirical material comes first, but on what grounds it is made into a case does not follow from the material itself. Soss puts the point directly. A case is "something we make", and what we make is "an analytic construct that we develop through our efforts to theorize the phenomena we study" (Soss, 2021, p. 85). The question is therefore not whether the Republican People's Party qualifies as a member of some pre-existing class, concept, or an ideal type, but what it should be treated as a case *of*. It is treated here as a case of opposition discourse under sustained executive aggrandizement. That decision carries a consequence for the design. What is asked is what happens to the opposition's own articulations over time, not how they fare against the incumbent's, and a corpus holding one party's speech answers the first question while it would not answer the second.

Weyland places Erdoğan alongside Orbán among the leaders who converted a parliamentary majority won in the wake of economic crisis into a series of power-concentrating institutional transformations, and so came to overpower the opposition (Weyland, 2025, p. 7). Such leaders, on this account, "rise when countries suffer from serious problems or crises, which 'the establishment' failed to combat effectively" (Weyland, 2025, p. 2).

Bermeo points to the AKP as an illustrative case of aggrandizement, where elected executives weaken checks on their power one by one and without being replaced: its parliamentary strength underwrote the "quiet revolution" Erdoğan had promised, enabling a record output of new legislation (Bermeo, 2016, p. 11). Esen (2021) further

documents the Turkish instance, arguing that the dismantling ran through the judiciary, the bureaucracy and the media in sequence, from the court packing of 2010 to the purges that followed the 2013 corruption probe (Esen, 2021, pp. 153–159). He dates the collapse of the democratic regime to before the July 2016 coup attempt. The corpus therefore opens inside the competitive authoritarian period rather than across the transition into it, and what it records is not a regime changing but an opposition speaking under one that has already changed.

On theoretical accounts, Laclau excludes the CHP's founding ideology *Kemalism* from populism on precisely this ground, since *halkçılık* "excludes any notion of antagonism or internal division" and rests on "a vision of a Turkish nation constituted not of classes but of solidary, closely interdependent occupational groups" (Laclau, 2005, p. 209). More importantly, examining the CHP through PDT means analysing the discursive positioning of a party that once founded the Republic and now occupies the position of the main opposition.

Table 4.1 sets out the period, and seven moments in it are treated as critical events.

Table 4.1: Chronology of the corpus period, with the number of speeches per year.

Year	n	Theme	Key events
Phase 1 — Kılıçdaroğlu, early			
2015	65	Elections and security	June election leaves a hung parliament; Suruç and Ankara station bombings; November snap election restores an AKP majority
2016	129	Coup attempt and security	Six mass-casualty attacks; **coup attempt, 15 July**[a]; state of emergency declared, 20 July; HDP co-chair Demirtaş arrested
2017	216	Referendum and the March for Justice	**Constitutional referendum, 16 April**[a]; replacing the parliamentary system; CHP's "No for my future" campaign; March for Justice, Ankara to Istanbul, 15 June–9 July
2018	199	Elections and alliances	**Presidential and parliamentary elections, 24 June**[a]; contested by the Nation Alliance; the presidential system takes effect, 9 July; state of emergency expires; currency crisis from 10 August
Phase 2 — Kılıçdaroğlu, late (from 1 Apr 2019)			
2019	241	Twin local elections	**Local elections, 31 March**[a]; Istanbul annulled and rerun on 23 June, won by İmamoğlu with a wider margin
2020	109	Earthquakes and pandemic	Elazığ and İzmir earthquakes; first Covid case in March, first nationwide curfew in April
2021	206	Istanbul Convention and pandemic	Withdrawal from the Istanbul Convention announced in March; record wildfire season in July and August; *helalleşme* enters the corpus, 27 February
2022	224	Economy, security, Table of Six	Six opposition parties convene in February and sign a joint declaration to restore a strengthened parliamentary system; İstiklal Avenue bombing; inflation above 85 per cent
2023	274	Earthquakes, elections, leadership change	Earthquakes of 6 February, some 53,000 dead; **elections, 14–28 May**[a]; narrowly lost, Table of Six dissolved; Gaza becomes a defining issue; **Özgür Özel elected leader, 8 November**
Phase 3 — Özel (from 5 Nov 2023)			
2024	511	Local elections, Kurdish opening, first arrest	**Local elections, 31 March**[a]; CHP first nationally for the first time in 46 years; *normalleşme* enters the corpus, 4 April; Bahçeli's call to Öcalan in October; Esenyurt mayor arrested and replaced by a trustee
2025	443	Judicial operations and the Saraçhane protests	**İmamoğlu's degree annulled and his arrest, 18–23 March**[a]; Saraçhane rallies for over 100 days; PKK lays down arms, 12 May; a trustee panel imposed on CHP's Istanbul organisation in September
2026[b]	108	Continuing crackdown	By April, 23 elected CHP mayors jailed since the 2024 local elections and 25 suspended from office

[a] One of the seven dislocations analysed in Table 6.1.
[b] First quarter only; the corpus ends on 31 March 2026.
Entry dates for *helalleşme* and *normalleşme* are their first attested occurrences in the corpus, not the dates of first public use.

Four of these are dislocations proper, marked dislocation, in that the existing discursive structure could not symbolise them within its own terms: the coup attempt, the referendum that replaced the system, the annulment of the Istanbul result, and the arrest of the opposition's presidential candidate. The remaining three are ordinary elections and serve as a comparison, since an ordinary election tests the same discourse without suspending the terms in which it is made. Two boundaries divide the corpus:

01 April 2019 marks the point at which the party takes municipal office (where KK_{Early} terminates), and 08 November 2023 marks the change of leader.

5 Methodology

5.1 Data and Preprocessing

The corpus consists of speeches delivered by the two leaders of the Republican People's Party between 13 January 2015 and 31 March 2026, collected in March 2026 from the party's own website at https://chp.org.tr. Listing pages were traversed by category to obtain the address, date and title of every speech back to a cutoff of 1 January 2015, each speech was then retrieved, the speaker was assigned from the title, and material attributable to neither leader was discarded. Requests were spaced by a fixed delay and the crawler identified itself, its academic purpose and a contact address in its user agent, so that the load placed on the server remained minimal.

Each speech carries the venue in which it was delivered, since the site organises its material by setting and the corpus keeps that division: parliamentary addresses, rallies, party events, press statements, party conventions and television appearances.

The site is the only source holding the full range of settings in one place, and it is under the party's own editorial control. That control is why the material has to be cleaned, since what is published is not only the leader's words, and six steps were applied in sequence.[1] All six protect the same thing, which is that the context surrounding a signifier should be the leader's own, because the analysis reads that context as the trace of an articulation.

[1] In order: transcriber parentheses such as applause markers were removed; editorial spot blocks set in capitals were deleted; third-person introductions written by the site's editors were stripped; attribution tags placed around quotations were removed; turns belonging to interviewers and other speakers were dropped from television and press material; and speeches shorter than fifty words were discarded.

Three text representations were then built from the cleaned material and two of them are used.[2] The semantic layer works on `text_bert`, because the model it uses is built to "pre-train deep bidirectional representations from unlabeled text by jointly conditioning on both left and right context in all layers" (Devlin et al., 2019, p. 1), and that context is the sentence as it was spoken. Punctuation and function words belong to that sentence rather than being noise around it, and removing them would strip the connectives through which one element is tied to another. The lexical layer works on `text_lemma`, because Turkish is agglutinative and counting a lemma's many inflected forms separately would treat one element of an equivalence chain as several (Oflazer, 2014; Çöltekin et al., 2023).

5.2 Methods

Articulation operates at the level of ontology. It says what discourse is and how meaning comes to be partially fixed, but it does not say which stretch of text to read, how much of it, or on what grounds one reading should be preferred to another. A method built on it therefore has to answer a question the theory leaves open. *How can articulations be represented in a text?*

The answer taken here rests on a bridge between two traditions that do not usually meet. On one side is the distributional hypothesis, in Firth's formulation that "you shall know a word by the company it keeps" (Firth, 1957, p. 11). On the other is articulation, defined by Laclau and Mouffe as "any practice establishing a relation among elements such that their identity is modified as a result of the articulatory practice" (Laclau & Mouffe, 1985, p. 105). These are different claims, and this thesis does not treat them as equivalent. What it does claim is narrower. If a signifier is repeatedly placed in the

[2] `text_bert` keeps case, punctuation, stopwords and suffixes, removing only web addresses, handles and applause markers. `text_clean` is Turkish-lowercased and stripped of punctuation but keeps stopwords and is not lemmatised. `text_lemma` is normalised, lemmatised with Zemberek (Akın & Akın, 2007; Çöltekin et al., 2023), then passed through a manual stem dictionary that merges inflectional variants the lemmatiser leaves apart.

same discursive company, that recurrence leaves a *distributional trace*, and a cluster of such recurrences can be read as *the trace of an articulation*. The cluster is not the articulation itself, and it is not treated as one (Jacobs & Tschötschel, 2019; Walton & Boon, 2014). It is evidence that a particular linking of elements was made often enough to become visible (Glasze, 2007a).

A design of this kind belongs to what Alejandro calls text-as-discourse computational discourse analysis, which "integrates discourse analysis as the guiding analytical framework with computational tools from QTA/NLP" and "builds on the methodological strengths enabled by text-as-data while reintroducing conceptual commitments that earlier computational approaches often left behind" (Alejandro, 2026a, p. 11). This sets it apart from text-as-data approaches, where the corpus is abstracted into features and the pattern is left to carry the interpretation on its own (Grimmer & Stewart, 2013). Within that category the workflow here is theory-led rather than fully integrated, since it begins from a question posed in Laclau's terms and then selects tools capable of investigating it (Alejandro, 2026a). The sequence is the one Nelson describes for computational grounded theory, in which an unsupervised procedure surfaces patterns the researcher did not select, which are then read closely and checked against the pattern that produced them (Nelson, 2020).

Four signifiers are analysed: *hak* (right), *demokrasi* (democracy), *millet* (the nation) and *halk* (the people). Each is matched by a single expression written for that signifier alone, which excludes the unrelated forms that would otherwise be gathered under it by accident; *hak* required the most work, since many unrelated Turkish words begin with the same three letters. Certain phrases are also locked before matching begins, so that the *halk* inside the party's own name, *Cumhuriyet Halk Partisi*, is never counted as an occurrence, and the same rule covers the governing party's name. This matters for the argument rather than for accuracy alone, since counting a party name as an occurrence of *halk* would place organisational self-reference inside an equivalence chain where it does not belong. The expressions are reproduced in full in the appendix.

Every occurrence is then represented by a *contextual word embedding*, which is a vector produced for that occurrence rather than for the word type, taking a window of fifteen words on either side. The model is BERTurk, a BERT architecture pre-trained on Turkish (Devlin et al., 2019; Schweter, 2020), and the uncased variant is used because capitalisation in this corpus is applied by the site's transcribers rather than by the speaker, as the capitalised editorial blocks removed during cleaning make clear, so a cased model would separate forms of the same word on a distinction that carries no discursive information.

A static embedding would assign one vector per word type, so *halk* would carry a single meaning across the whole corpus and the variation this thesis looks for would be averaged away before the analysis began (Arseniev-Koehler, 2024). Diachronic designs that align a separate static model per period recover movement between periods but still allow a signifier only one meaning within each (Hamilton et al., 2016). A contextual model gives one vector per occurrence, which is the unit an articulation requires (Giulianelli et al., 2020; Zhang et al., 2025).

Two decisions shape what those vectors carry. The target word is replaced by a mask before the vector is taken, so that the model cannot see the signifier itself and the vector is built from its surroundings (Yamada et al., 2021). Without this an unmasked vector would encode the word's own form and would group occurrences by surface shape rather than by the company they keep. Table A.4 shows the effect directly, since two high-frequency inflected forms are each distributed across roughly twice as many clusters after masking and whitening. The resulting space is then whitened, since contextual representations are known to be anisotropic and to place frequent words in crowded regions of the space (Ethayarajh, 2019; Zhou et al., 2021; Sasaki et al., 2023; Su et al., 2021). Without this step the analysis would recover how often a form is used rather than how it is articulated. Whitening is fitted for each signifier across the whole period at once, so it cannot manufacture a difference between phases.

$$\tilde{X} = (X - \mu)\, V\Lambda^{-1/2}V^{\top}, \qquad \Sigma = V\Lambda V^{\top} \tag{5.1}$$

where X is the matrix of occurrence vectors for one signifier, μ its mean, and $V\Lambda V^{\top}$ the eigendecomposition of the covariance Σ.

The vectors are reduced with UMAP and clustered with HDBSCAN (McInnes et al., 2020; McInnes et al., 2017). Clustering is carried out without any information about when a speech was delivered, because the phases are what the analysis compares and building them into the clustering would decide the result in advance. HDBSCAN was chosen over methods that assign every point to a cluster, since an articulation is a recurrence and occurrences that do not recur should be left aside rather than forced into a group; these are reported as noise and carried through the tables. Reduced dimensions were set per signifier after a sensitivity check (Table A.1), and cluster counts, noise and silhouette scores appear in Table A.2 (Rousseeuw, 1987).

The clusters are read in two consecutive steps. First, each cluster is described by the terms that distinguish it from the others. Treating every cluster as a document, terms are weighted by their frequency within the cluster against the number of clusters in which they appear, following the class-based TF-IDF set out for BERTopic models (Grootendorst, 2022). Second, Zemberek POS filtering is applied to to report content words and verbs separately.

$$w_{t,c} = \frac{f_{t,c}}{\sum_{t'} f_{t',c}} \cdot \log\!\left(\frac{1 + |C|}{1 + \mathrm{df}_t}\right) \tag{5.2}$$

where $f_{t,c}$ is the frequency of term t in cluster c, $|C|$ the number of clusters, and df_t the number of clusters in which t occurs.

Inflected forms are merged before ranking, terms appearing fewer than five times in a cluster are set aside, and content words and verbs are reported separately, since a list dominated by inflectional variants of one stem would describe the grammar of the

cluster rather than what it articulates.

Clusters were then read and grouped into meta-clusters, treated as nodal points around the signifiers. This grouping was done on the content of the clusters and on concordance lines drawn from the raw text, and it was done without reference to when the occurrences fell, so that the interpretive step and the temporal comparison remain independent. Clusters that did not form an interpretable node were left ungrouped and excluded, and the proportion this affects is reported for each signifier in Table A.3.

The comparison across periods is made with a lift, which sets a meta-cluster's share within a phase against its share across the corpus as a whole.

$$\text{lift}(c, p) = \frac{n_{c,p}/n_c}{N_p/N} \tag{5.3}$$

where $n_{c,p}$ is the number of occurrences of meta-cluster c falling in phase p, n_c the size of that meta-cluster, N_p the number of occurrences of the signifier in phase p, and N its total.

A value of one means the articulation is present in proportion to the size of the phase, and values above or below show where it concentrates or thins out. No single number is used to express how far a signifier has moved overall, because measures of that kind were tested and found to confound articulatory change with the difference between two speakers and with ordinary lexical variation. The size of that first confound is reported in Table A.6, and a second, the changing mix of venues across phases, in Table A.5. The analysis therefore stays with the lift structure and with close reading, which is the retroductive movement between concept and case that discourse-theoretical work requires (Glynos & Howarth, 2019).

A second layer works on the lemmatised corpus and does not use the embeddings at all. Around each critical event, the words that enter and recede in symmetric three-month windows are identified by log-likelihood keyness (Dunning, 1993), a procedure drawn from corpus-assisted discourse studies (Partington et al., 2013; Flowerdew, 2023).

This layer answers a question the first cannot, since clusters show how a signifier is articulated while keyness shows which elements the discourse takes up and drops around a given moment. Reading the two together is the design principle of the analysis rather than an addition to it (Compton, 2025; Nikisianis et al., 2019).

5.3 Reflexivity

Reflexivity, in Alejandro's formulation, is the practice of making explicit the beliefs and dispositions that shape knowledge production and of examining how they influence analytical choices (Alejandro, 2026b). Arriving from articulatory practices at interpretable clusters reflects my own reading of post-structuralist discourse theory, and three decisions carry that reading into the results.

The first is the grouping of clusters into meta-clusters. This was done by hand and on the content of the clusters, and what counted as an interpretable node was settled by the same reading that supplied the concepts. Table A.3 reports the share left ungrouped for each signifier, which is the part of the material that reading could not place.

The second is the treatment of *demokra* as a single stem, so that *demokrasi* and *demokrat* were gathered under one expression (Table A.9). Had they been separated, the movement from a form of state to a plural subject would have appeared as two signifiers rather than as one signifier changing its grammatical form.

The third is the selection of the four signifiers, which was made on theoretical grounds and not because the procedure required them. A different reading of the same tradition would have selected differently and would have found a different pattern.

The operationalisation is therefore suggestive rather than definitive, and travelable across cases as comparable designs in other fields have been (Rear & Jones, 2013).

6 Findings

6.1 Lexical Analysis

Table 6.1: Log-likelihood keyness (Dunning, 1993) of CHP discourse around seven critical events (signifier-independent): words that ENTER (keyness +) vs. RECEDE (keyness −) across the event, in symmetric ±3-month windows ($\geq$ 5 speeches). Events marked † are treated as dislocations. Each event reactivates a *distinct* register rather than following a single law, consistent with the singularity of dislocation. Lemma artefacts merged (*üre→üretim*); place-names omitted.

Dislocation	**Enters (reactivated)**	**Recedes**
Coup attempt, Jul 2016†	coup[1], state of emergency, merit, republic, secular	immunity, production[2], minimum wage, lira, electric, **dictator**, tourism, aid
Referendum, Apr 2017†	justice, coup, prosecutor, march[3], illegitimate, legitimate, palace	no, constitution, nation, national, **one-man rule**, authority, Syria
General election (loss), Jun 2018	**crisis**, tender, central bank, waste, dollar, debt	small business owner, sugar (factories), peace, women, education, pensioner, school, women, **tutelage**, candidate
Local election, Mar 2019†	justice, certificate of election, judge, conscience, annulment	nationalism, service, **privatisation**, lira, **factory**, queue, municipality, neighbourhood, tax
General election (loss), May 2023	**Erdoğan**, debt, journalist, moral, fraudster, montage, convention, media, will	rights of the servant[4], pensioner, youth, **gang of five**, earthquake, penny, teacher, justice, school, vow verbs[5]
Local election, Mar 2024	constitution, first, **Gezi**, **normalisation**, negotiation, IMF, curriculum, weath, public	pensioner, alliance, candidate, lira, gold, palace, DEM Party, Erdoğan
İmamoğlu arrest, Mar 2025†	İmamoğlu, Saraçhane, **(civil) coup, junta**, trustee[6], slander, boycott, youth, terror-free, Silivri, bribe, diploma	minimum wage, livelihood, pensioner, salary, women, forest fire, earthquake[7]

The lexical layer works on the lemmatised corpus and asks a question about elements rather than about senses (Laclau & Mouffe, 1985, p. 105). Around each of the seven critical events in Table 6.1, the words that enter and recede across a symmetric three-month window are identified by log-likelihood keyness. What the table shows first is that there is no single law of dislocation. Each event reactivates a distinct register: the coup attempt brings in the vocabulary of the coup, merit and secularism; while dictator is receding, the referendum brings in justice, the prosecutor and the palace, and the arrest of İmamoğlu brings in Saraçhane, the trustee and the civil coup. The registers do not overlap.

One regularity does hold across them, and it concerns what leaves rather than what arrives. At the coup attempt the terms that recede are production, the farmer, the minimum wage, the lira and electricity. At the 2019 local elections they are the lira, the factory, the queue and taxation. At the arrest of İmamoğlu they are the minimum wage, livelihood, the pensioner and salaries. The same register withdraws each time, which is the vocabulary in which the party had been making economic claims.

Table 6.2 tracks that register across the whole period rather than in a single window, measuring the corpus share of the eighteen terms in which those claims are made, month by month.[8] The register contracts by roughly a third at four of the seven events and returns within four to seven months, and does not contract at the other three.

[1]And coup-related terms such as FETÖ, religious sect (*cemaat*), july, attempt.
[2]And production-related terms such as farmer, agriculture, nut, product
[3]The 2017 Justice March (*Adalet Yürüyüşü*).
[4]*Kul hakkı* — "the rights of God's servants," a moral/corruption idiom.
[5]Promise, I/we will bring, we will make, you will see.
[6]*Kayyum* — a government-appointed trustee replacing an elected mayor.
[7]And earthquake-related terms such as Adıyaman, Hatay, Kahramanmaraş, container housing.
[8]The terms are altın, bütçe, dolar, döviz, ekmek, fiyat, geçim, işsiz, konut, kuruş, lira, maaş, maden, para, prim, vergi, zam and ücret, the last of which carries *asgari ücret*. No single term accounts for more than 22 per cent of the group. The baseline is the twelve months preceding an event, and recovery is the first month in which the smoothed series regains ninety per cent of it.

Table 6.2: Withdrawal and recovery of the economic-demand register around the seven critical events. Change is measured against the twelve months preceding the event; recovery is the first month in which the register regains ninety per cent of that baseline.

Event	Type	Change	Recovery
Coup attempt, Jul 2016	dislocation	−43%	4 months
Referendum, Apr 2017	dislocation	−37%	4 months
Local election, Mar 2019	dislocation	−35%	6 months
İmamoğlu arrest, Mar 2025	dislocation	−34%	7 months
General election, Jun 2018	election	+83%[a]	—
General election, May 2023	election	+26%	—
Local election, Mar 2024	election	+4%	—

[a] The currency crisis of August 2018 falls inside this window, so the event is itself economic.

The exception is as informative as the rule. At the June 2018 election the register does not withdraw but expands by more than eighty per cent, because the currency crisis of that August falls inside the window and the event is itself economic. Had the withdrawals been a matter of attention alone, with an acute event crowding everything else out of the speeches, the register would have contracted here too. It responds to what the event is about rather than to the fact that an event occurred. The three ordinary elections show no contraction at all, so what withdraws the register is not the electoral calendar but the suspension of ordinary rules.

Read against Laclau's criteria, what this register tracks is a demand that persists without being met. It withdraws when the ordinary rules are suspended and returns months later in the same terms, and a demand that had been absorbed institutionally would not return at all (Laclau, 2005, p. 73).

Two further lexical results are reported in the appendix. The PPMI neighbourhood of *helalleşme* is almost entirely replaced when the term activates (Table A.7), and the six-arrow Kemalist terminology shifts towards nationalism and away from secularism across the phases (Table A.8).

This is the limit of what counting elements can establish. It shows which terms the discourse takes up and drops around a given moment, and how long a register takes to return, but it counts occurrences and cannot distinguish uses. The four signifiers make the limit plain. Measured per ten thousand words, three of them fall between the first phase and the third: *hak* from 19.2 to 12.0, *demokrasi* from 27.6 to 14.1 and *halk* from 10.2 to 6.2. *millet* moves the other way and rises from 14.2 to 22.1.[9] A frequency account can say that the party came to speak less of rights, of democracy and of the people and more of the nation, but not whether *hak* means the same thing when it is used less often, nor what *millet* has come to hold when it is used more. Those are questions about the company a signifier keeps, and the semantic layer addresses them. Following the Laclau, I shall begin the semantic analysis with the Turkish word that is able to capture *quantitatively* more demands and identities around itself, which is *hak* (right).

6.2 Semantic Analysis

The four signifiers are treated in turn. Each is read from its phase-lift heatmap and its meta-clusters, and the reading asks the same two questions of all of them: which articulations recede, and where the occurrences that remain are gathered. The answers differ enough that the four cannot be described in a single vocabulary, and the closing section of this chapter sets the four patterns against one another.

6.2.1 *hak*: Dispersal

The juridical core of *hak* does not survive the period. The Right, Law and Justice node is the largest articulation in the first two phases and falls from a lift of 1.4 to 0.3,

[9]The phases differ substantially in size, at roughly 1.5, 1.8 and 2.6 million words, so raw occurrence counts are not comparable across them. The counts given in the figure captions are unnormalised and describe the distribution of occurrences rather than the intensity of use.

and the corruption node built on *kul hakkı*, the rights of God's servants, falls from 1.3 to 0.6. Together these are the registers in which a right was something guaranteed by law or owed as a moral debt, and both leave. What rises in their place is distributive. The economic node moves from 0.6 to 1.6 and gathers the pensioner, the farmer, the lira, the minimum wage and the civil servant, and the women's rights node moves from 0.8 to 1.5.

Dispersal is not the same as incoherence (Jacobs, 2021), and two of the nodes *hak* moves into are internally organised. Economic vocabulary concentrates rather than spreading evenly, since the most economic of its clusters carries such terms at seven times the rate of the median cluster, so the economic articulation is a place where claims are gathered rather than a general drift towards money. The women's rights articulation is organised differently and it changes. Across the five clusters in which women's vocabulary is densest, the early phase is built on political rights, with the vote, eligibility for office, the republic supplying the terms, and the language of violence absent. In the Özel phase that register remains but the *right to life* enters alongside it, and the vocabulary of violence and killing appears at a rate that had been close to zero. The articulation is widened rather than replaced, and what it comes to hold is the intersection of a claim against the system with those whose right to life has been degregaded.

An idiolect component cannot be excluded here, since the change falls at the speaker change and the corpus offers no way to separate the two. What can be said is that the difference is registered in the clustering itself. The occurrences are separated in a twelve-dimensional reduction of the embedding space before any of this vocabulary is counted, so the separation tracks a distinction in how the claim is made rather than a difference in who is speaking.

What *hak* does not do is settle. Its occurrences leave the juridical nodes and spread across the economic, the constitutional, women's rights and labour without accumulating in any of them, and no articulation in the third phase approaches the concentration

the Right, Law and Justice node held in the first two. This is a movement without a destination, and it is reported here as such rather than assimilated to one of the patterns the other three signifiers show.

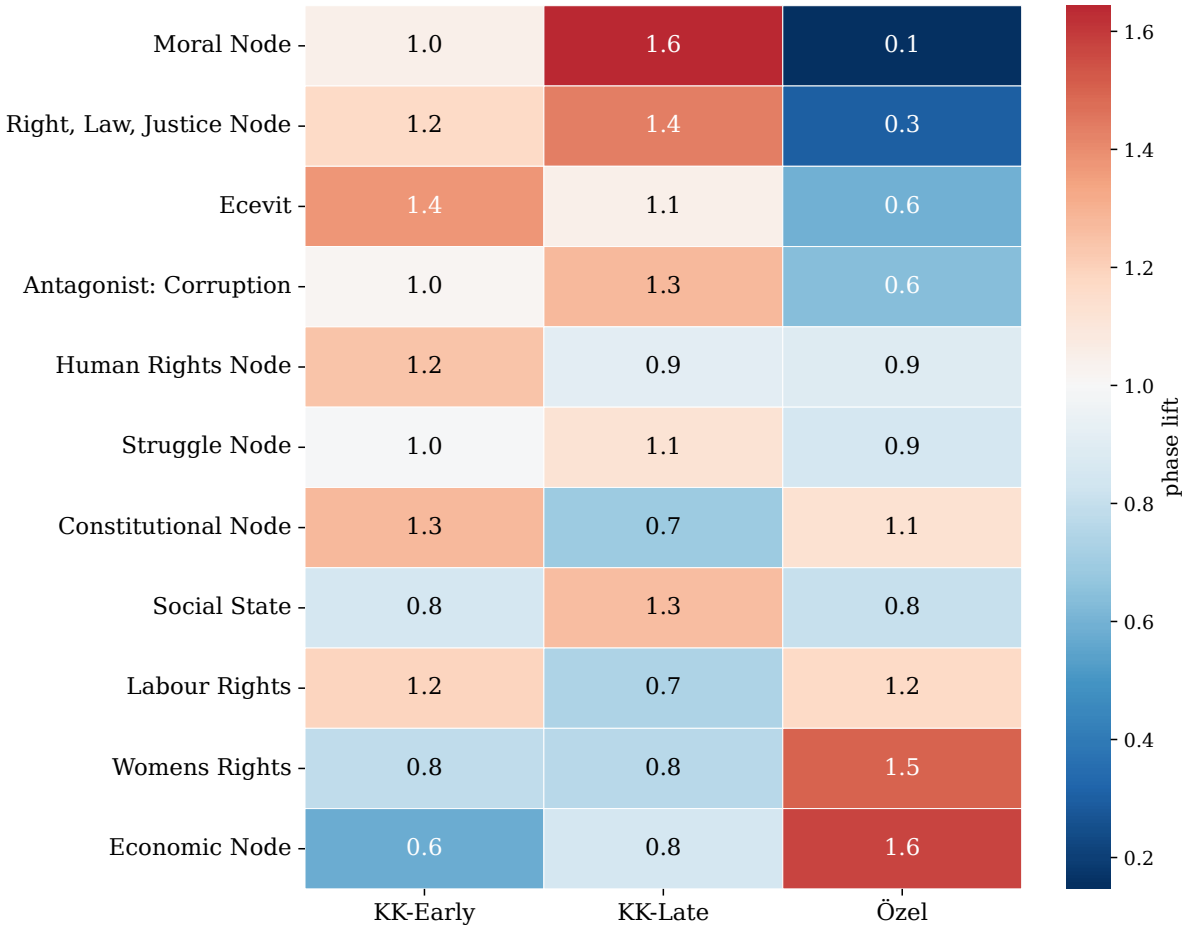


Figure 6.1: Phase lift of *hak* meta-clusters across the three phases. Of 10,009 unique occurrences, 7,598 clustered by HDBSCAN (24% noise), 6,566 assigned to interpretive meta-clusters. Lift is the ratio of a cluster's share within a phase to its share across the whole corpus. A value of 1.0 denotes proportional presence. Values above or below indicate relative concentration or scarcity. Full meta-clusters and term lists appear in the Supplementary Information, Table S1.

Table 6.3: Selected contextual meta-clusters of *hak* and their phase-specific lift. Representative terms are selected and ordered by c-TF-IDF score. Parenthetical counts are frequencies, with morphological inflections merged into a single lemma (see Section 5.2). Out of 10,009 unique occurrences, phase-specific frequencies are: KK_{Early} = 2863, KK_{Late} = **3983**, *Özel* = 3163. Terms in red mark antagonist vocabulary.

Cluster (n)	KK-E	KK-L	Özel	Representative terms (freq.)
Right, Law, Justice Node (870)	1.2	**1.4**	0.3	law (841), justice (469), right (279), country (219), struggle (169), party (166), [is the] way (26), human (127), democracy (133), state (125)
Antagonist: Corruption (718)	1.0	**1.3**	0.6	**kul hakkı**[a] **(731)**, violate (110),Mr. Kemal[b](81), interview (39), sin (98), orphan (46), unfledged (40), attempt (24), right (106), human (101), nation (93), covenant[c](24), politics (109), july (35), party (86), waste (22), money (73), state (94), bribe (20), corruption (71)
Human Rights Node (665)	**1.2**	0.9	0.9	right (618), human (686), court[d](261), democracy (286), violation (158), decision (155), commission[e] (47), country (173), constitution (168), Europe (140), law (104)
Constitutional Node (834)	**1.3**	0.7	1.1	right (634), constitution (274), democracy (136), citizen (128), state (136), freedom (72), party (124), *sahip* (to own / to protect)[f] (127), budget (99), demonstration (26), liberty (19), rally (23), court (87)
Social State (251)	0.8	**1.3**	0.8	right (212), premium (36), social (163), state (123), favour (38), retirement (84), logic (16), security (80), rural (20), woman (61), access (12), insurance (40)
Labour Rights (500)	**1.2**	0.7	1.2	right (311), worker (196), personnel rights (37), union (126), *sahip* (101), collective [bargaining] (37), human (93), pensioner (75), demand (50), officer (19), strike (51), mine (17)
Womens Rights (386)	0.8	0.8	**1.5**	woman (366), right (177), rally (42), revolution (23), alimony (19), country (80), Switzerland (18), property (16), Greece (16), life (81), inheritance (20)
Economic Node (959)	0.6	0.8	**1.6**	right (316), raise (81), pensioner (214), farmer (167), money (174), lira (162), worker (141), party (158), [minimum] wage (107), civil servant (35), country (129), orphan (33), inflation (19), children (80)

[a] "The right of God's servants" is Islamic moral idiom for violating another's rights, used as a corruption accusation in Kılıçdaroğlu's discourse.
[b] Erdoğan referred to Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu as "Bay Kemal" in a mocking tone. Kılıçdaroğlu later reappropriated the label against Erdoğan himself, for instance *"He [Erdoğan] can't say 'I wouldn't violate another's rights.' Only Mr. Kemal says that."*.
[c] On 21 July 2016, Türkiye notified the UN Secretary-General under Article 4 of the ICCPR (International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights) that it was derogating from thirteen articles under the state of emergency. These include the right to a fair trial (Article 14) and humane treatment of detainees (Articles 7 and 10).
See OHCHR (2016).
[d] European Court of Human Rights
[e] Human Rights Commission at Turkish Grand National Assembly
[f] The Turkish noun *sahip* means "owner," but its meaning shifts with the verb it accompanies: *sahip olmak* ("to own") versus *sahip çıkmak* ("to protect, to stand up for"). Both senses occur in CHP discourse.

6.2.2 *demokrasi*: Replacement

demokrasi undergoes the most complete replacement of the four. The register that dominates the first phase is institutional, and it does not survive. The parliamentary system and constitution node falls from a lift of 1.9 to 0.4, taking with it the vocabulary of the system, the regime, the constitution and secularism, and the demands node falls from 1.4 to 0.4, taking rights, freedom, justice and the promise. By the third phase neither is doing substantial work.

What replaces them barely existed before. The largest of the new articulations is the Türkiye Alliance node, which holds democrats, conservatives, nationalists, liberals, Kurds, Circassians, Laz, Sunnis and Alevis in the same context (Laclau, 2005), and it has a date. Through 2015 to 2023 it appears at two or three occurrences a month. In March 2024, the month of the local elections, it appears ninety-three times, and it does not fall back afterwards. The node is overwhelmingly Özel's, with 458 of its 529 occurrences his.

The grammatical form the signifier takes inside that node is itself the evidence. Ninety-eight per cent of its occurrences are the plural noun *demokratlar*, democrats, against thirty-one per cent across the signifier as a whole.[10] The contrast with the early register is exact. Kılıçdaroğlu uses the word as an adjective qualifying a form of state, as in the constitutional formula that the Republic is a "demokratik laik sosyal hukuk devleti", a democratic, secular, social state governed by the rule of law, or in the objection that "parlamenter demokratik sistemi alıyoruz bir tarafa bırakıyoruz", we are taking the parliamentary democratic system and setting it aside. Özel uses it as a plural noun that names groups and sets them in a row: "Türkiye'nin sosyal demokratları muhafazakar demokratları milliyetçi demokratları Kürt demokratları Laz demokratları Çerkes demokratları", Turkey's social democrats, conservative democrats,

[10]The expression written for this signifier matches on the stem *demokra*, so *demokrasi*, *demokrat* and *demokratik* are gathered together. This is a decision taken at the matching stage rather than an accident of lemmatisation, and the distribution of forms across articulations is treated here as a finding rather than as noise to be removed.

nationalist democrats, Kurdish democrats, Laz democrats, Circassian democrats.

The signifier therefore does not migrate between existing articulations. It is rebuilt on a different set, and the set that replaces the old one is organised around a collective political subject rather than around an institutional arrangement. The contrast with *millet* is not one of degree. Where *millet* widens a chain it already had, *demokrasi* leaves one chain and is invested in another, which is the more radical of the two operations.

Where the first phase asked what democracy consists of, naming the parliamentary system and the constitution, the third asks who the democrats are.

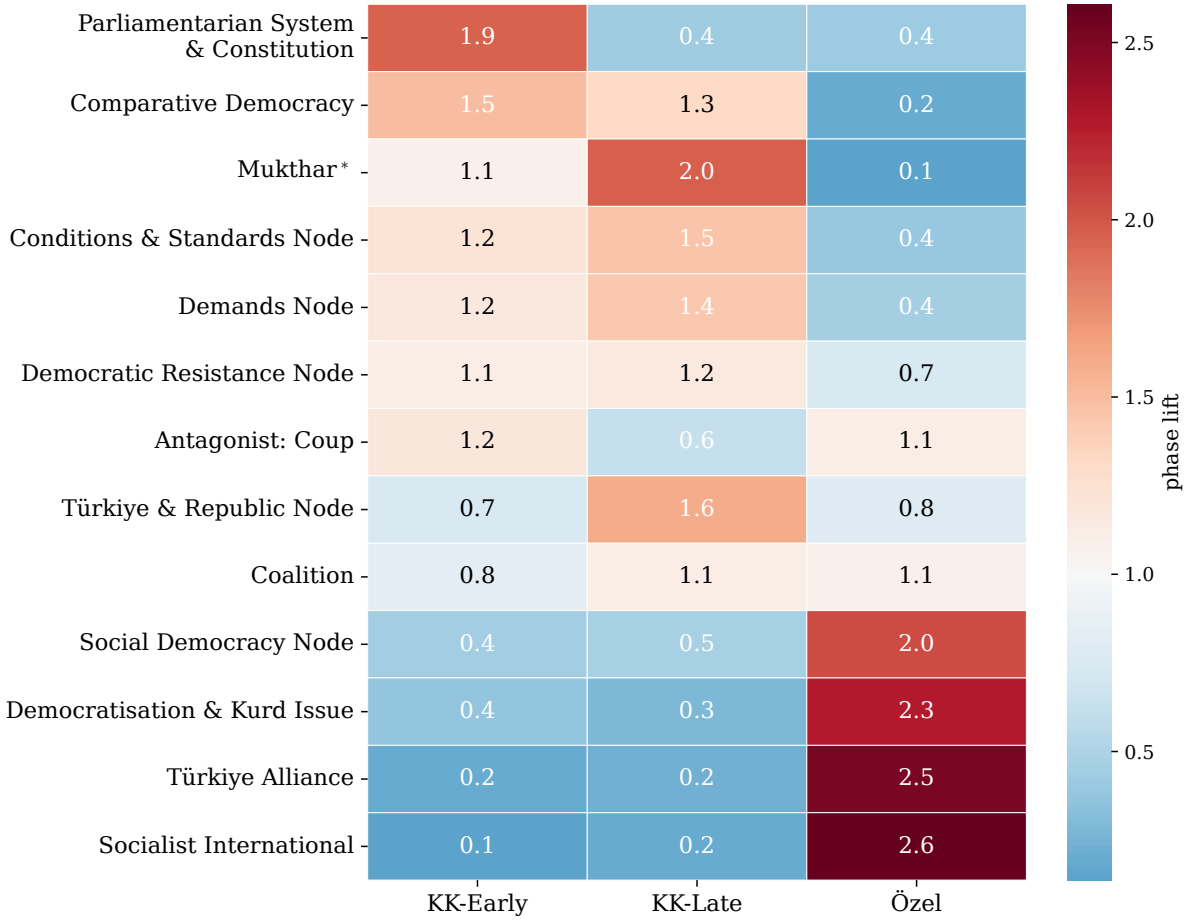


Figure 6.2: Phase lift of *demokrasi* meta-clusters across the three phases. Of 10,911 unique occurrences, 8,604 clustered by HDBSCAN (21% noise), 6,727 assigned to interpretive meta-clusters. Lift is the ratio of a cluster's share within a phase to its share across the whole corpus. A value of 1.0 denotes proportional presence. Values above or below indicate relative concentration or scarcity. Full meta-clusters and term lists appear in the Supplementary Information, Table S2.

Table 6.4: Selected contextual meta-clusters of *demokrasi* and their phase-specific lift. Representative terms are selected and ordered by c-TF-IDF score. Parenthetical counts are frequencies, with morphological inflections merged into a single lemma (see Section 5.2). Out of 10,911 unique occurrences, phase-specific frequencies are: KK_{Early} = **4105**, KK_{Late} = 3066, $Özel$ = 3740

Cluster (n)	KK-E	KK-L	Özel	Representative terms (freq.)
Parliamentarian System & Constitution (385)	**1.9**	0.4	0.4	secular (96), system (264), parliamentarian (299), state (211), regime (161), law (142), proposal (32), social (137), constitution (80), republic (93)
Demands Node (1090)	1.2	**1.4**	0.4	democracy (445), right (289), law (234), freedom (203), country (196), justice (186), party (147), problem (128), human (129), tax (98), citizen (110), promise (155), media (119)
Democratic Resistance Node (582)	1.1	**1.2**	0.7	[through democratic] means (178), struggle (195), feast (25), cost (41), democracy (141), shame (24), ballot (105), right (87), history (70)
Antagonist: Coup (1023)	**1.2**	0.6	1.1	democracy (416), [nation's] slap (55), coup (146), dictatorship (50), train[a](37), tutelage (43), autocracy (35)
Türkiye & Republic Node (835)	0.7	**1.6**	0.8	country (379), democracy (374), republic (297), party (129), true (120), deserve (94), identity (25), sense (102), election (81), century (31), youth (73)
Social Democracy Node (371)	0.4	0.5	**2.0**	social (400), municipality (214), democrat (279), *SODEM*[b](36), party (126), [Kemalist] populist[c](23), left (33), leftist (18)
Democratisation & Kurd Issue (246)	0.4	0.3	**2.3**	democratisation (192), terror-free (55), Kurd (47), package (23), issue (80), steps (16), commission (43), non-custodial (12), politics (51), appointed administrator (11), shackles (8)
Türkiye Alliance (529)	0.2	0.2	**2.5**	democrat (1583)[d], conservative (245), Kurd (257), alliance (421), liberal (97), social (354), nationalist (303), Circassian (51), colours (42), Laz (50), haram[e] (36), sun (37), Sunni (33), Alevi (35)

[a] Özgür Özel uses this word referring to Erdoğan's widely criticised 1996 statement, made while he was Mayor of Istanbul: *"Democracy is like a tram. You ride it until you arrive at your destination, then you step off."* Turkey Institute, 2016.
[b] Social Democrat Municipalities Association, established in 2011.
[c] *Halkçılık*, one of the Six Arrows of Kemalism, denoting solidarism and the rejection of class division. It is not populism in the ideational sense used in the regime literature, nor in the Laclauian sense adopted here.
[d] Frequency of democracy in this cluster is 27.
[e] Religiously forbidden.

6.2.3 *millet*: The Widening Chain

millet is the only signifier used more intensively at the end of the period than at the beginning, rising from 14.2 to 22.1 occurrences per ten thousand words, and it is also the one that spreads across the widest range of articulations. Its founding register recedes. The foundation node, which holds Amasya, the war of independence, the congress and the republic, falls from a lift of 1.6 to 0.6, and the sovereignty node holds level without growing.

Everything else rises, and the articulations that rise have little in common with one another. The antagonist node, the largest of the signifier at 1,440 occurrences, moves from 0.7 to 1.2 and holds Erdoğan, the prosecutor, poverty and the demand that he get off the nation's back. The nation's will node moves to 1.2 with the ballot, the candidate and sagacity. The state node moves from 0.4 to 1.5 with the police, the soldier and the state broadcaster. The peasant node moves to 1.5 with the farmer, the pensioner and the small business owner. The resistance node built around İmamoğlu moves from 0.2 to 1.7.

Read together these movements describe a signifier that is being asked to carry more and more that is unlike itself (Zicman de Barros, 2025). The clearest instances are those in which *millet* is not described at all but invoked as the ground of a judgment, as in the observation that a court ruling is issued "Türk Milleti adına", in the name of the Turkish Nation, or in the formula that sovereignty belongs to the nation "kayıtsız şartsız", unconditionally and unreservedly. In these uses the signifier has no particular content. It is not the peasant, nor the electorate, nor an ethnic description, but the name in which legitimacy is conferred, and it can be attached to the farmer, the resister and the electorate at once because it has ceased to be any of them in particular. What grows is the chain rather than the term. *millet* admits new content without shedding what it already holds, and it therefore becomes extensionally fuller and intensionally poorer at the same time (Laclau, 2005, p. 96).

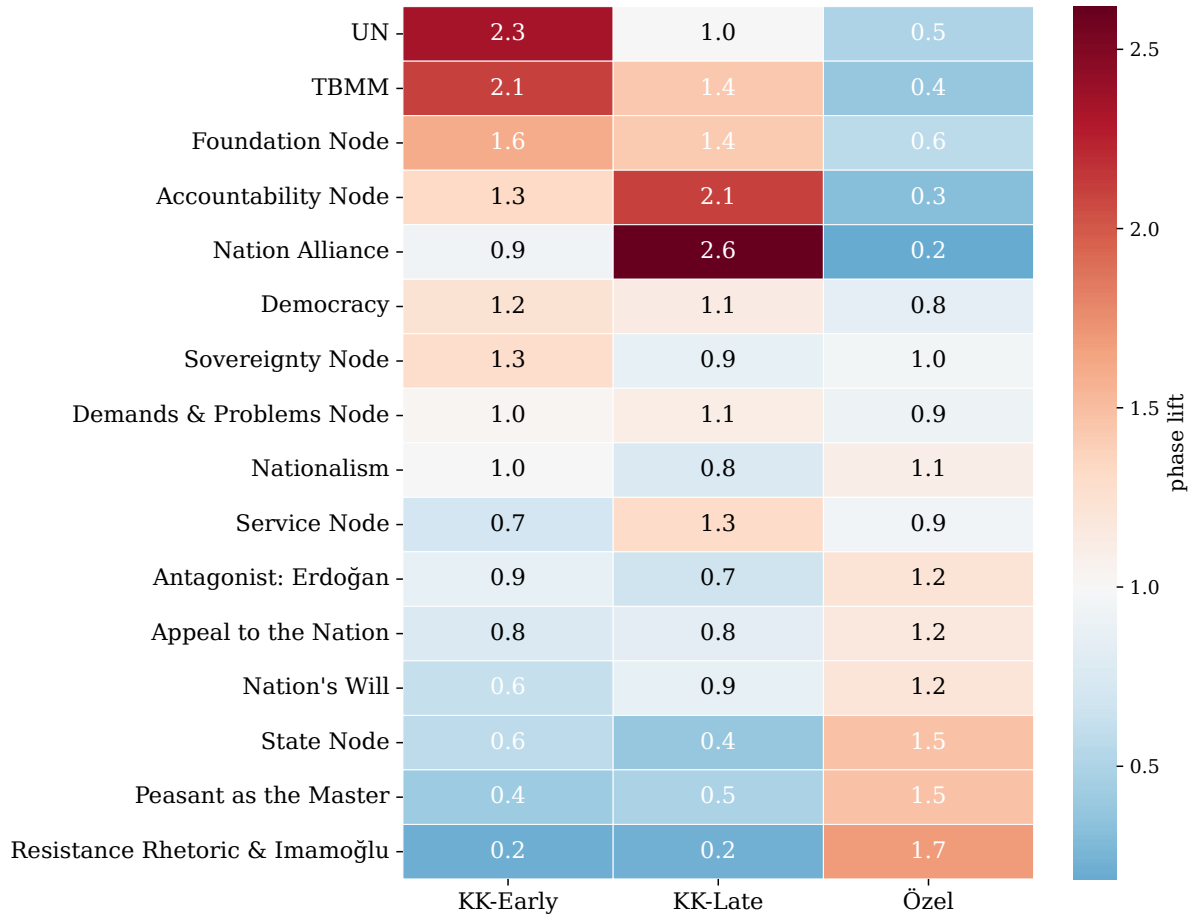


Figure 6.3: Phase lift of *millet* meta-clusters across the three phases. Of 10,976 unique occurrences, 8,473 clustered by HDBSCAN (23% noise), 7,628 assigned to interpretive meta-clusters. Lift is the ratio of a cluster's share within a phase to its share across the whole corpus. A value of 1.0 denotes proportional presence. Values above or below indicate relative concentration or scarcity. Full meta-clusters and term lists appear in the Supplementary Information, Table S3.

Table 6.5: Selected contextual meta-clusters of *millet* and their phase-specific lift. Out of 10,976 unique occurrences, phase-specific frequencies are: $KK_{Early} = 2109$, $KK_{Late} = 3023$, $Özel =$ **5844**

Cluster (n)	KK-E	KK-L	Özel	Representative terms (freq.)
Foundation Node (270)	**1.6**	1.4	0.6	nation (417), oppressed (77), independence (52), determination (59), Amasya (54), independence [war] (42), circular (23), destiny (27), congress (20), country (78), decision (67), republic (83), war (52), education (12)
Sovereignty Node (399)	**1.3**	0.9	1.0	sovereignty (182), nation (581), castle (106), unconditionally (103), unreservedly (103), *bila kaydü şart*[a] (33), sovereignty[b](35), constitution (103), representative (26)
Nationalism (330)	1.0	0.8	**1.1**	love (95), nation (248), heart (59), motherland (170), flag (143), [my] honour (36), colours (41), alliance (115), türkiye (149), stars (31), indivisible whole (19), Turk (113), [my] power (16), Atatürk (99), [nation's] power (28)
Antagonist: Erdoğan (1440)	0.9	0.7	**1.2**	nation (1244), Erdoğan (257), party (268), conscience (128), [to nation's] face (48), mayor (166), intelligence[c] (32), prosecutor (39), get off [the nation's] back (37), queue (28), poverty (40), political (136), power (145), coup (129), election (135), raise (37)
Nation's Will (922)	0.6	0.9	**1.2**	nation (834), will (253), election (271), party (289), sagacity (58), Erdoğan (102), people (168), power (148), decision (112), mayor (125), democracy (152), vote (33), candidate (77), municipality (106), [nation's] power (31), coup (103), president (107)
State Node (350)	0.6	0.4	**1.5**	state (449), nation (408), interests (42), agency (40), against (137), police (35), son (63), Kenan Evren[d] (24), bullet (19), party (90), Turgut Özal[e], Erdoğan (35), [on the] side (37), soldier (39), Anatolia (24), TRT[f](15), district governor (9), election (46)
Peasant as the Master (136)	0.4	0.5	**1.5**	master (159), peasant (89), *ananı*[g](46) , farmer (114), nation (159), agriculture (13), president (55), pensioner (29), price (7), husbandry (6), miserable (12), citrus (5), Atatürk (37), small business owner (18)
Resistance Rhetoric & Imamoğlu (535)	0.2	0.2	**1.7**	nation (581), heart (122), party (234), inch (51), Erdoğan (82), word (29), to defy [the nation] (20), mayor (88), eye [of the nation] (61), survey (18), municipality (78), Ekrem Imamoğlu (54), less (30), people (89), against (58), coup (72), election (73)

[a] An Ottoman-Turkish phrase meaning "unconditionally."
[b] *Hakimiyet*, synonym for *egemenlik* (the first word in this cluster). Both mean sovereignty.
[c] Here in the sense of mocking or insulting the nation's intelligence, i.e. treating the people as gullible.
[d] Chief of the General Staff who led the 1980 military coup and subsequently served as the 7th President of Türkiye (1982–1989).
[e] Prime Minister (1983–1989) and later 8th President of Türkiye (1989–1993).
[f] Turkish Radio and Television Corporation, the national public broadcaster founded in 1969.
[g] On 11 February 2006 in Mersin province of Türkiye, then-Prime Minister Erdoğan told a farmer who complained about farmers' hardship ("our mothers wept") to *"take your mother and get lost!" (anamı da al git, kaybol!)*. The farmer was subsequently detained and faced numerous lawsuits. See Worldcrunch (2024).

6.2.4 *halk*: Sedimentation

halk moves in the opposite direction on every measure. Its rate falls from 10.2 to 6.2 occurrences per ten thousand words, and two of its articulations do not merely recede but effectively disappear. The democracy and media node, which holds the journalist, the outlet and the voice of the people, falls from a lift of 2.1 to 0.2. The accountability node, which holds accountability, the penny, taxation and ethical understanding, falls from 1.5 to 0.1. These are the registers in which *halk* was the party to whom an account was owed.

The occurrences that remain gather in two places. The popular will node holds at 1.1 and the CHP and service node rises to 1.3, and both are organised around the party itself, its mayors, its municipalities and the services they deliver. *halk* thus becomes what the party serves and whose will the party carries, and it is used in a narrower range of contexts at the end of the period than at any earlier point.

This is the observable form of sedimentation. Laclau writes that the social consists only in "the sedimented forms of a power that has blurred the traces of its own contingency" (Laclau, 1996, p. 103), and a sedimented articulation is not one that has ceased to be contingent but one whose contingency is no longer visible. It does not present itself as a choice among possible articulations. *halk* in the third phase is not argued for or contested but simply used, and the range of company it keeps has narrowed to the point where the articulation carries no alternative within it.

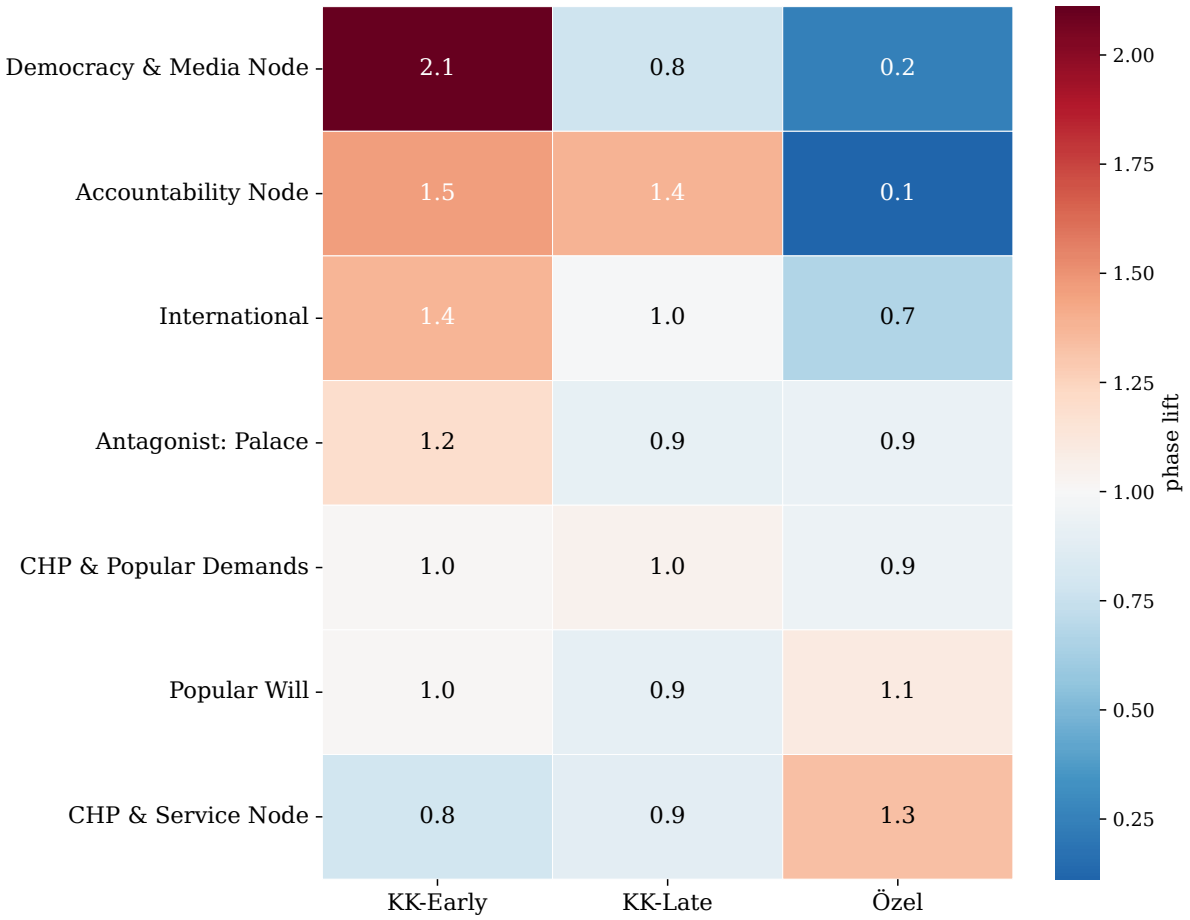


Figure 6.4: Phase lift of *halk* meta-clusters across the three phases. Of 5,086 unique occurrences, 3,975 clustered by HDBSCAN (22% noise), 2,828 assigned to interpretive meta-clusters. Lift is the ratio of a cluster's share within a phase to its share across the whole corpus. A value of 1.0 denotes proportional presence. Values above or below indicate relative concentration or scarcity. Full meta-clusters and term lists appear in the Supplementary Information, Table S4.

Table 6.6: Selected contextual meta-clusters of *halk* and their phase-specific lift. Representative terms are selected and ordered by c-TF-IDF score. Parenthetical counts are frequencies, with morphological inflections merged into a single lemma (see Section 5.2). Out of 5,086 unique occurrences, phase-specific frequencies are: $KK_{Early} = 1513$, $KK_{Late} = \mathbf{1938}$, $Özel = 1635$

Cluster (n)	KK-E	KK-L	Özel	Representative terms (freq.)
Democracy & Media Node (129)	**2.1**	0.8	0.2	media (63), eye (18), ear (18), journalist (41), outlet (13), democracy (62), people (66), voice (12), türkiye (33), election (26), power (10), oppression (20), to protect (25), mass (6)
Accountability Node (360)	**1.5**	1.4	0.1	people (488), accountability (277), politics (200), town (29), penny (74), tax (58), mayor (68), nation (72), municipality (71), money (55), ethical (19), understanding (58)
Antagonist: Palace (536)	**1.2**	0.9	0.9	people (598), [15] july (139), palace (173), modest (47), country (134), municipality (124), rich (97), mayor (97), nation (82), candidate (20), poor (26)
CHP & Popular Demands (256)	1.0	**1.0**	0.9	party (403), people (293), problems (89), wall[a](16), republic (90), agenda (48), [minimum] wage (15), struggle (55), right (56), labourer (13), police (38), poor (14), pensioner (35), farmer (32), worker (27)
Popular Will (644)	1.0	0.9	**1.1**	people (624), popular rule (261), will (180), order (46), nation (146), party (125), mayor (104), election (107), state (106), democracy (120), power (30), right (83), country (97)
CHP & Service Node (749)	0.8	0.9	**1.3**	people (578), municipality (453), [Kemalist] populist (153), town (109), mayor (290), service (302), lira (67), restaurant[b](42), politics (208), project (40), party (159), bread[c](47), unearned income (40)

[a] Resistance metaphor by Kılıçdaroğlu: *"There are walls before Kılıçdaroğlu that you can't cross. The wall of justice, the wall of rights, the wall of the people; you cannot cross those walls to reach me!"* (08.11.2022)
[b] *Halk Lokantası* ("People's Restaurant"), a subsidised catering service established by the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality (İBB) during the İmamoğlu period.
[c] *Halk Ekmek* ("People's Bread"), a long-standing subsidised bread service run by the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, established in 1977.

6.3 Four Patterns

The four signifiers are read here on the same two questions, which are what happens to the articulation that dominated the early corpus and where the occurrences that remain are gathered. Table 6.7 sets the answers against one another.

Table 6.7: The four signifiers compared. Rate is occurrences per ten thousand words. Lifts are taken from the meta-cluster tables above.

	Rate	Early register	Where the mass moves	Pattern
millet	14.2 → 22.1	foundation recedes, 1.6 → 0.6	across eight unlike nodes, none dominant	spreading
demokrasi	27.6 → 14.1	parliamentary system collapses, 1.9 → 0.4	into three nodes that barely existed, to 2.0, 2.3 and 2.5	replacement
halk	10.2 → 6.2	media and accountability collapse, to 0.2 and 0.1	into two party-centred nodes	narrowing
hak	19.2 → 12.0	law and justice collapses, 1.4 → 0.3	across four nodes without concentration	dispersal

The patterns are not variants of a single movement, and Chapter 7 reads them against Laclau's vocabulary, where three of the four are recognisable and one is not.

7 Discussion

Table 6.7 reports four movements and no common one. *millet* is used more at the end of the period than at the start and comes to appear across articulations that have little to do with one another, while the founding register that once anchored it recedes. This is the position Laclau describes when he writes that the only possible totalizing horizon is given by "a partiality (the hegemonic force) which assumes the representation of a mythical totality" (Laclau, 2005, p. 116). *halk* moves the other way. It contracts into two party-centred articulations and ceases to present itself as a choice among possible ones, which is sedimentation (Laclau, 1996, p. 103). *demokrasi* neither empties nor settles. Its institutional register collapses and is replaced by articulations that barely existed before and that are organised around a collective political subject rather than an institutional arrangement.

hak shows the floating dimension most clearly of the four. It leaves its juridical register without accumulating anywhere else, and a signifier whose meaning is suspended between rival hegemonic projects loses its footing in exactly this way (Laclau, 2005, p. 131). What this design cannot do is name the project that pulls on it, since that is a relation between two discourses and the corpus holds one of them.

Taken together these are not four instances of one process. A signifier is being emptied, a second is settling, a third is being rebuilt and a fourth is coming apart, and they are doing so at the same time and in the same discourse. What the party does not have, on this evidence, is a single signifier around which the others are organised. *millet* is available for that role and is doing the work of an empty signifier, but the chain does not close around it, because the three other signifiers examined here are moving

in three further directions.

The premise of the design is stated by the party itself. Six weeks before the March 2024 local elections, in the speech where the Kurdish link first enters the chain, Özel reports the failure of the negotiations he had conducted since taking office. In his words, "we could not build an alliance in Ankara, we could not agree in Ankara and build an alliance across Turkey". What follows is not a retreat but a substitution. The eleven metropolitan municipalities were not won by the candidates and not by the parties, and the sentence that completes the thought names the winner as an electorate that has not changed. The enumeration of democrats then follows in the same paragraph, in the place of the protocol that was not signed. Coordination in the literature on opposition alliances is measured in protocols, joint candidacies and signatures (Yavuzyılmaz & Esen, 2025; Esen et al., 2026). Here the actor marks the point at which that measure stops applying and carries the work to another level, which is the level this thesis observes.

This bears on the disagreement left open in Chapter 2. Weyland (2025) argues that opposition agency is a poor object of study because the opposition is primarily reactive and the initiative lies with the incumbent. The evidence here answers on two levels and the answers differ. At the level of elements the opposition is reactive in a measurable way, since the register in which it makes economic claims withdraws at every event that suspends the ordinary rules and takes between four and seven months to return. At the level of articulation it is not. The rearticulation of *millet* runs across the whole period and is not organised by the incumbent's calendar, and the replacement of *demokrasi* builds a register that no dislocation introduced. Whether the opposition is reactive therefore depends on what is being counted, and an account resting on outcomes and events will find reactivity because those are the units in which it looks.

7.1 Contribution and Future Work

Three extensions follow directly. The four signifiers were selected on theoretical grounds rather than because the procedure requires them, and the same pipeline applies to any term frequent enough to cluster, which makes the selection a matter of argument rather than of method. The comparison across phases is reported here as a description of where an articulation concentrates, and no sampling distribution is placed behind it. With a corpus that separates speaker from period, the movements could be tested rather than described, and the scalar summaries of how far a signifier has travelled that were built and set aside for the reasons given below become usable at the same point.

Empirically, the study finds that meaning does not consolidate on a single empty signifier but disperses across several signifiers, a pattern it terms *distributed articulation*.

The study suggests a new operationalisation for Post-Structuralist Discourse theory by bridging distributional semantics and the Laclauian notion of articulation. The study contributes to the understanding of Türkiye's autocratisation trajectory and the opposition's positioning through a text-as-discourse approach.

It also assembles and makes publicly available a corpus of the party's speeches, providing a resource for further research.

7.2 Limitations

The clearest limit is that the phases are defined by time but the last of them coincides exactly with a change of leader, since Kılıçdaroğlu speaks throughout 2015 to 2023 and Özel throughout 2023 to 2026 with no overlap. A content-free stylometric comparison puts a bound on how large this is: function-word style alone separates the two leaders at an AUC of 0.97, against 0.70 for two Kılıçdaroğlu sub-periods used as a placebo (Table A.6). An idiolect component is therefore present in the third phase and cannot

be removed. Two features of the results nonetheless argue against reading them as idiolect alone. The four signifiers move in four different directions, whereas a speaker effect would be expected to move them together, and each movement is legible as a response to a datable conjuncture rather than to a change of voice. The exposure is not equal across the four, and the Türkiye Alliance articulation of *demokrasi* is the most exposed of them, since 458 of its 529 occurrences are Özel's. Separating speaker from period properly would require Özel's parliamentary speeches from his years as group deputy chair, which lie outside a corpus built from the party leadership's own platform.

The analytical apparatus derives from a theory of populism, and this raises a question the thesis does not settle. In Laclau's account the construction of a people through chains of equivalence is what populism names, which would make the articulatory shifts traced above populist by definition, while the ideational and strategic literatures classify parties by ideological content or by leadership style (Rooduijn, 2019; Stavrakakis, 2024) and would reach their conclusions on different evidence. The Laclauian logic is used here as an instrument for describing articulation, and the findings are not offered as evidence that the CHP is a populist party under any of these definitions.

The interpretation of clusters rested for the most part on concordance lines (Partington et al., 2013), since reading every occurrence at this scale was not feasible. Each cluster was approached through its ranked terms and then through a sample of the lines in which the signifier appeared, and the notes made in that reading are recorded in the analysis notebooks. This keeps the interpretive step open to inspection, but it also means the evidence behind a given meta-cluster label is a sample of its contents rather than the whole.

A second corpus was needed and was not built. Establishing that a signifier floats requires showing how the opposing project articulates the same term, and what the incumbent *did* is documented above through Bermeo's account of executive aggrandizement (Bermeo, 2016, p. 10) while how the incumbent *speaks* is not. Only the latter would settle whether a signifier is contested or merely unstable.

A further limit follows from the model. BERTurk is pre-trained on general Turkish text rather than on political speech, and its training material predates most of the corpus, so a sense specific to this discourse, or one that emerged during the period studied, is represented only insofar as general usage supports it. Fine-tuning on political language would address this and was not attempted here.

Appendix A

Robustness and Sensitivity Analyses

Table A.1: n_components sensitivity per signifier. For each signifier, HDBSCAN (`min_cluster_size` of 25, `min_samples` of 8) was run on UMAP embeddings across candidate dimensionalities. The selected value balances three goals: retaining a high number of clusters (finer thematic resolution) while keeping noise low. Where these trade off, preference was given to the configuration in the stable mid-range rather than the extremes. Cluster counts and noise vary within a narrow band across all dimensionalities, indicating results are robust to this choice.

Signifier	n_comp	clusters	noise %
hak	5	113	20.0
	8	108	18.2
	10	104	17.2
	12	**108**	**17.9**
	15	105	18.6
	20	103	18.8
demokrasi	5	131	20.0
	8	125	20.7
	10	**130**	**19.3**
	12	129	21.5
	15	125	21.0
	20	123	20.5
millet	5	132	24.1
	8	131	23.6
	10	**128**	**22.8**
	12	131	24.1
	15	131	23.9
	20	124	23.4
halk	5	68	24.5
	8	65	25.0
	10	68	23.9
	12	64	22.9
	15	**64**	**21.8**
	20	61	22.6

Table A.2: Cluster features and quality per signifier. Clusters were fit with `min_cluster_size` of 25 and `min_samples` of 8 (HDBSCAN), on UMAP-reduced embeddings using the per-word `n_components` shown. Silhouette scores are reported in the full 768-dimensional BERTurk space and in the reduced UMAP space. Cluster counts here include the subclusters produced by a second pass over clusters that combined distinct senses; the counts in Table A.5 exclude them.

Signifier	`n_comp`	occurrences	clusters	noise	sil. (768d)	sil. (UMAP)
hak	12	10009	144	24.1%	0.063	0.778
demokrasi	10	10911	132	21.1%	0.058	0.766
millet	10	10976	128	22.8%	0.057	0.820
halk	15	5086	64	21.8%	0.041	0.699

Table A.3: Meta-cluster coverage per signifier. Number of HDBSCAN clusters assigned to an interpretive meta-cluster, and the share of clustered occurrences these grouped clusters account for. Ungrouped clusters were small or thematically dispersed and left unassigned.

Signifier	grouped / total clusters	ungrouped	occurrence coverage
hak	124 / 144	20	86%
demokrasi	101 / 132	31	78%
millet	111 / 128	17	90%
halk	46 / 64	18	71%

Table A.4: Effect of masking and whitening on contextual spread across clusters, for two high-frequency forms. Lower HHI and higher effective cluster counts indicate that occurrences of the same form are distributed across more distinct contextual clusters rather than collapsed into few.

	hakkını		*demokrasinin*	
Metric	normal	maskwhite	normal	maskwhite
clusters w/ form	57	87	38	93
HHI	0.072	0.036	0.123	0.053
N_{eff}	13.9	27.9	8.1	18.9
clusters (90%)	19	41	11	46

Table A.5: Venue confounder check for clusters (subclusters excluded). For each signifier, the number of clusters flagged as venue-weighted (dominant venue share exceeding the corpus expectation by more than 20 percentage points, with purity above 60%). The low flag rate indicates that clusters capture discursive rather than venue-driven structure.

Signifier	clusters	venue-flagged	% flagged
hak	108	7	6.5%
demokrasi	130	6	4.6%
millet	128	9	7.0%
halk	64	5	7.8%

Table A.6: Content-free stylometric comparison of the two party leaders, by phase (509 Turkish function words and coarse features computed on raw speech text). The Kılıçdaroğlu→Özel style gap is 2.3× the within-Kılıçdaroğlu (P1 vs P2) gap, and a function-word classifier separates the two speakers at AUC 0.97 versus 0.70 for two Kılıçdaroğlu periods. An idiolect component is therefore present in the Özel-phase discourse; it cannot, however, account for the signifier-specific and content-coherent rearticulations traced in the findings, and is addressed in the Discussion.

	KK-Early	KK-Late	Özel
Words per sentence	10.90	10.44	12.38
Mean word length (chars)	6.13	6.17	5.99
Lexical diversity (MATTR)	0.696	0.706	0.734
Function-word style distance (standardized centroids)			
P1↔P2 (within Kılıçdaroğlu)		2.32	
P2↔P3 (Kılıçdaroğlu→Özel)		5.34	
Function-word classifier (5-fold CV ROC-AUC)			
Kılıçdaroğlu vs Özel (speaker)		0.97	
P1 vs P2 within Kılıçdaroğlu (period placebo)		0.70	

Table A.7: Co-occurrence shift around *helalleşme* ("reconciliation/asking for absolution"). Window: ±16 months around 2021-11-01, i.e. the before-period spans 2020-07 to 2021-11 ($n_{\text{before}} = 17$ documents) and the after-period spans 2021-11 to 2023-03 ($n_{\text{after}} = 330$). Jaccard overlap of the PPMI neighbourhoods = 0.04, indicating an almost complete replacement of the signifier's context. The new neighbours cluster around previously sedimented traumas and grievances, consistent with a Laclauian sedimentation.

New PPMI neighbours after *helalleşme* activates (selected, thematic)
Sedimented traumas / massacres (reactivated): Roboski, Soma, Sivas, Kahramanmaraş, Şanlıurfa, Diyarbakır; massacre-linked terms: burning/fire (*ateş*), the young (*gencecik*), martyr-like youth, novel (*roman*), film
Justice, guilt and absolution: justice (*adalet*), law (*hukuk*), the judiciary (*yargı*), court (*mahkeme*), prison / prison-house (*hapis, hapishane*), sin (*günah*), guilt/fault (*kabahat, kusur*), to forgive (*affet*), to atone / reckon (*hesaplaş*), to confront (*yüzleş*), the rights of others (*kul_hakkı*), public treasury (*beytülmal*)
Antagonism and grievance: torture (*işkence*), to kill (*öldür*), execution (*idam*), oppression (*zulüm*), pressure (*baskı*), corruption (*yolsuzluk*), theft (*hırsız, gasp*), revenge (*intikam*), rage (*öfke*), polarisation (*kutup*)
Affective / reconciliatory frame: embrace (*kucak, kucaklaş*), sibling/kin (*kardeş*), sincerity (*samimi*), heart (*yürek*), hope (*umut*), love (*sevgi*), peace (*barış*), self-criticism (*özeleştiri*), to atone/be cleansed (*arın*)
Identity groups drawn into the chain: Kurds/Diyarbakır, Alevi-coded references, headscarf (*başörtü*), the child (*çocuk*), women (*kadın*)

Table A.8: Six-arrow (Kemalist) terminology across the three phases, as a percentage of phase-level occurrences and total frequencies. Low-frequency terms (*Devletçilik*, *İnkılap*, *İhtilal* each $n < 15$) are omitted.

Term	total	KK-Early	KK-Late	Özel
Milliyetçilik (Nationalism)	676	17.64	21.85	**32.06**
Devrim (Revolution)	279	8.82	8.58	**12.61**
Laiklik (Secularism)	162	**10.81**	5.03	3.73
Halkçılık (Kemalist Populism)	138	1.42	2.52	**9.41**
Cumhuriyetçilik (Republicanism)	64	0.28	0.80	4.88

Table A.9: Matching expressions for the four signifiers, applied to Turkish-lowercased text. Negative lookaheads exclude unrelated forms sharing the same initial letters. The *demokra* stem deliberately gathers *demokrasi*, *demokrat* and *demokratik*; the distribution of these forms across articulations is reported in the findings.

Signifier	Expression
hak	`\bhak(?!kari|ir|em|kâri|im|kında|kımda|kımızda|kınızda|larında|ikat|aret|sız|an|lı|kaniyet|[-\s]?iş)\w*`
demokrasi	`\bdemokra\w*`
millet	`\bmillet(?!vekil|lerarası)\w*`, but TBMM left open (Türkiye Büyük Millet Meclisi)
halk	`\bhalk\w*`, with *Cumhuriyet Halk Partisi* locked as blocked phrases before matching begins

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